

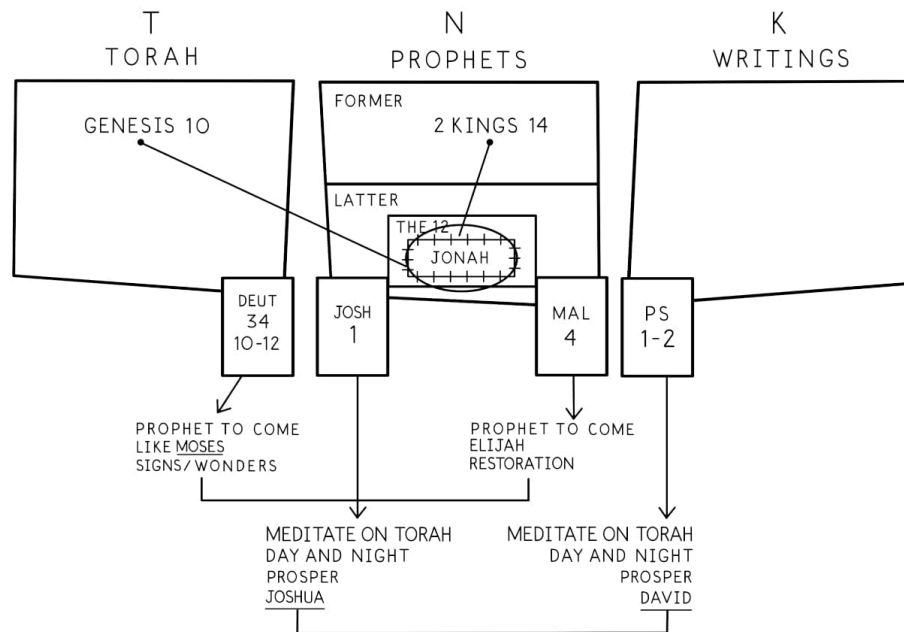
Session 8: The “Seams” of the TaNaK

Key Takeaways

- The seams of the TaNaK, or the beginnings and endings of the major sections, include repeated words and phrases that show the TaNaK is telling one overarching story of Israel’s need for a prophet like Moses and Elijah who will bring life to the nations.
- The Hebrew Bible is meditation literature (Josh. 1; Ps. 1) designed to foster (1) daily reading and pondering about the meaning of these texts, (2) a future hope in the promised prophet who will herald the messianic Kingdom, and (3) a covenantal way of life that is counter-cultural to prevailing world systems.

The Editorial Design of the TaNaK

The three-part shape of the Hebrew Bible isn’t simply a matter of arrangement. Rather, the books themselves have been designed to fit into this particular shape. If you look at the editorial seams of the major sections (remember the technology was papyrus or leather scrolls), you’ll find intentional design clues at the beginning and ending of these sections.



The Shape and Seams of the TaNaK, and Where Jonah Fits In. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Jonah (2019).

Seam 1: The Final Sentences of the Torah and the Opening Sentences of the Nevi'im

- Deuteronomy 34:10-12: Anticipation of a coming Moses-like prophet who was promised but never came.
- Joshua 1:1-9: God's appointed leader, Joshua, who will lead the people into the promised land, must meditate on the Torah day and night to find success.

Seam 2: The Final Sentences of the Nevi'im and the Opening Sentences of the Ketuvim

- Malachi 4:4-6: Anticipation of a coming Elijah-like prophet who will call the people back to the Torah and restore the hearts of Israel before the Day of the Lord.
- Psalms 1-2: The righteous one who will be vindicated in the final judgment is one who meditates on the Torah day and night to find success (Ps. 1). This righteous one is the future messianic king from the line of David, who is appointed by God to rule the nations and overcome evil once and for all (Ps. 2).

Hebrew Meditation Literature

The Hebrew Bible is meditation literature (Josh. 1, Ps. 1) and is designed to foster:

- Daily reading and pondering about the meaning of these texts
- Future hope in the promised prophet who will herald the messianic Kingdom
- A covenantal way of life that is countercultural to the prevailing world systems

Reflection Question

The seams of the TaNaK describe the kind of leader humanity needs. What is this person like?